DIGITAL LITERACY

PROJECT REPORT

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Date: 26.03.2026

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Introduction

Digital literacy is the ability to effectively navigate, evaluate, and use digital tools and platforms for communication, learning, and professional growth. In today's highly connected academic environment, interacting with technology securely and responsibly is an absolutely essential skill.

This project provided practical exposure to industry-standard tools and platforms, building a strong foundation for my core technical coursework. Specifically, it helped me understand how to:

- Use digital tools and developer platforms efficiently
- Communicate professionally online with faculty and recruiters
- Maintain online safety and awareness against modern cyber threats
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Through hands-on tasks ranging from designing visual infographics to analyzing financial cybercrime, I improved my technical, analytical, and communication skills. These competencies are essential for academic success and collaborating effectively in future software development environments.

Task 1: Infographic

For this task, I used **Canva** to design a one-page visual resource titled **"A Student's Guide to Digital Literacy"**. As a Student Digital Ambassador, I designed this infographic to help my batchmates understand essential digital skills and safety measures.

My design includes:

- A comprehensive definition of digital literacy.
- Actionable safe internet practices, specifically focusing on **Strong Passwords**, **Enabling 2FA**, and **Spotting Phishing**.
- Guidance on maintaining a professional online presence.
- A "Key Platforms" section highlighting the importance of LinkedIn and GitHub for students.

I utilized a grid-based layout with distinct sections, clear headings, and illustrative icons (like the padlock and shield) to ensure the information is professional and easy to digest at a glance.

One interesting/difficult aspect: The most interesting part of this task was using Canva's design features to translate technical concepts, such as Two-Factor Authentication, into simple, visually engaging advice. The most challenging aspect was condensing broad cybersecurity topics into short, punchy bullet points without losing the critical security details needed for effectiveness. This task significantly improved my ability to communicate technical information visually and concisely.

Task 2: Digital Portfolio

In this task, I created and updated professional profiles on **GitHub, LinkedIn, and HackerRank**, which form the foundation of my identity as a developer.

Platforms and their uses:

- **GitHub:** Used for version control, hosting my B.Tech coursework, and showcasing my Python repositories (such as my recent algorithms project).
- **LinkedIn:** Used for professional networking, connecting with industry professionals, and highlighting my current focus as a Python Developer and Hackathon Enthusiast.
- **HackerRank:** Used for practicing competitive coding, mastering Python syntax, and improving logical problem-solving skills.

My future plan (next 4 years):

- Regularly update GitHub with new hackathon builds and open-source contributions to create a verifiable code portfolio.
- Use LinkedIn to share project milestones, connect with VIT alumni, and actively seek software engineering summer internships.
- Consistently solve algorithmic challenges on HackerRank to build a strong foundation in data structures and algorithms for future technical interviews.

This task emphasized the importance of building a clean, professional digital footprint early in my college journey to support my long-term technical career goals.

Task 3: Platforms

In this task, I worked with **HackerRank, Google Forms, and Google Workspace (Forms Analytics)** to understand the practical applications of digital tools for both technical skill-building and data collection.

What I practiced/built:

- Solved foundational programming challenges (including conditional logic like Java If-Else and mathematical operations) on HackerRank.
- Designed a comprehensive "Digital Literacy Awareness Quiz" using Google Forms to test peers on password security, phishing identification, and netiquette.
- Simulated data collection by generating responses and analyzing the results through automated charts and linked spreadsheet views.

Solving algorithmic problems on HackerRank helped bridge the gap between the theoretical syntax learned in lectures and the practical problem-solving logic required for hackathons. Meanwhile, creating the Google Form quiz provided hands-on experience in structuring surveys and capturing user data efficiently.

Academic benefits:

- Strengthens logical thinking and foundational programming skills necessary for software development.
- Provides practical experience in designing digital surveys and gathering user data for academic research or team projects.
- Enhances the ability to interpret data visually using built-in form analytics and response graphs.

This task demonstrated how combining coding practice platforms with cloud collaboration tools can significantly enhance both individual learning and team-based data collection.

Task 4: Email Etiquette

In this task, I drafted two formal emails—an assignment extension request and a summer software engineering internship application—alongside a checklist for responsible social media use.

Poor digital communication can lead to serious misunderstandings. For instance, imagine a scenario where a student receives a lower-than-expected grade and immediately sends an emotionally charged email to their professor, accidentally hitting "Reply All" to a department-wide mailing list.

Problems caused:

- Severe professional embarrassment and miscommunication.
- Lasting damage to the student's academic reputation, leaving a negative impression.
- Strained relationships with university faculty and a potential delay in response.

What could be done differently:

- Step away from the screen to cool down before responding.
- Write a concise and clear message addressed exclusively to the professor, using a clear and relevant subject line.
- Start with a polite greeting and maintain a respectful and professional tone to constructively discuss the feedback.
- Always double-check the recipient fields (To, Cc, Bcc) before hitting send.

Following proper email etiquette ensures effective communication and helps maintain professionalism in academic and professional settings.

Task 5: Cybercrime Awareness

While researching cybercrime and creating a case study on UPI payment fraud for hostel fees, I was surprised by how psychologically manipulative these scams have become. Many students unknowingly authorize deductions by scanning QR codes or entering their PINs under the false assumption of receiving a pending refund.

What surprised me:

- Scammers specifically target the financial anxieties and busy schedules of college students with fake, urgent deadlines.
- Victims are easily tricked into entering their UPI PINs, even though a PIN is strictly for *sending* money, never for receiving it.

One habit I will change:

- I will stop automatically trusting urgent digital communication regarding fees, part-time jobs, or refunds.
- I will implement a strict "verify first" rule by independently checking claims through official university channels before opening any links or payment apps.

This task highlighted the immediate financial risks of digital transactions and the importance of remaining vigilant against modern social engineering tactics.

Conclusion

This project provided a comprehensive framework for understanding and applying digital literacy in a real-world academic context. Through hands-on experience with industry-standard developer platforms, I transitioned from a basic technology user to a more responsible and security-conscious digital citizen.

Overall, this project has equipped me with the foundational skills to:

- Manage a professional software developer portfolio effectively.
- Communicate with university faculty and industry professionals using proper etiquette.
- Identify and mitigate modern cyber threats, such as targeted UPI financial fraud.

These competencies establish a strong technical baseline that will be highly valuable as I progress through my B.Tech coursework and prepare for future hackathons and software engineering roles.

Key Learnings

- Gained a clear understanding of digital literacy and its importance in academic and professional environments.
- Learned how to effectively use multiple digital platforms such as GitHub, LinkedIn, HackerRank, Canva, and Google Forms.
- Understood the importance of maintaining a professional digital presence through properly structured online profiles.
- Developed awareness about cybersecurity risks, including phishing, fraud, and unsafe online practices.
- Learned how to present information visually using infographics, making complex ideas easy to understand.
- Improved knowledge of data collection and analysis using tools like Google Forms and Google Sheets.
- Gained insight into professional communication, especially writing formal emails with proper etiquette.
- Understood how digital tools can be used for collaboration, learning, and project management.

Skills Gained

1. Technical Skills:
    - Basic programming and problem-solving using HackerRank
    - Using GitHub for file management and project organization
    - Creating and managing online forms and response sheets
2. Communication Skills:
    - Writing formal and professional emails
    - Structuring clear and concise digital messages
    - Understanding tone and etiquette in online communication
3. Design Skills:
    - Creating visually appealing infographics using Canva
    - Organizing content using layouts, icons, and color schemes
    - Presenting information in a clear and engaging format
4. Analytical Skills:
    - Identifying online risks and evaluating digital information
    - Understanding cybercrime patterns and prevention methods
    - Analyzing responses collected through forms
5. Organizational Skills:
    - Managing multiple tasks and platforms efficiently
    - Structuring files and folders correctly in GitHub
    - Maintaining a clean and professional project repository

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References

- Canva (https://www.canva.com)
- GitHub (https://github.com)
- LinkedIn (https://www.linkedin.com)
- HackerRank (https://www.hackerrank.com)
- National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal (https://cybercrime.gov.in)